
CHURN IS DEAD

The Frozen Layer Audit

Mapping your operating model to its true origin: you, or the vendor's defaults

This audit exposes your Vendor-Default Ratio — the share of how your CS team works that exists because the tool ships that way, not because you chose it. Score each layer honestly, then count how many decisions you can't change without filing a vendor ticket.

Scoring: Rate each item 1-5. 1 = the vendor decided this and we can't change it without permission; 5 = we deliberately decided this and could rebuild it in any tool.

Created by: Kuber Sethi

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SECTION 1

The Definitions Layer

The most dangerous frozen decisions arrive disguised as obvious. 'Healthy means engaged' feels like physics, but it's a product default written by someone who never met your customer.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Origin of your health score logic	Each input was chosen and weighted because it predicts outcomes in YOUR product, and you can explain why	You inherited the platform's default scoring template and never interrogated whether login frequency means love or breakage for your product
Definition of 'at-risk'	Risk reflects what actually threatens your accounts (e.g. budget exposure, stable-but-invisible products) including signals the platform has no native field for	'At-risk' equals 'declining usage' because that's what the tool flags — even where falling logins mean the product is finally working
Definition of 'enterprise' / account class	Tiers are defined by strategic dimensions you chose, documented independently of any field in the tool	'Enterprise means over X seats' because that's the band the platform groups on by default
Ability to change a core definition	You can redefine 'healthy' this quarter without a Professional Services scope or a ticket	Changing the score requires fighting the platform's scoring logic, a vendor ticket, or a PS engagement

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
Every core definition (healthy, at-risk, enterprise) is documented and justified against your product, not the vendor's template	1-5
Your health score captures the real failure modes of your accounts, including signals the platform has no field for	1-5
You can change a definition without vendor permission, tickets, or PS scoping	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 2

The Workflow Layer

Tools have grain. Teams drift toward the smooth paths whether or not they're right, and over time 'the order the screens are in' gets written into the onboarding deck as if it were a philosophy.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Why CSMs run plays in a given sequence	A CSM can articulate a strategic reason for the order of every recurring motion	The honest answer is 'because that's the order the screens are in'
Origin of daily CSM motions	Each recurring motion exists because it's right, and you've tested it against alternatives	Motions exist because they're the lowest-friction path the tool offers — you've never checked if they're correct
Onboarding deck for new hires	Documented motions reflect deliberate philosophy you can defend independent of the tool	The deck encodes the platform's information architecture as if it were your operating procedure
Separation of habit from tool grain	You've audited which easy paths are also the right ones and which aren't	Team habits and the tool's grain are indistinguishable — nobody can tell which is which

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
Every recurring CSM motion has a defensible strategic rationale beyond 'it's how the tool works'	1-5
Your onboarding documents deliberate process, not the platform's screen flow	1-5
You have actively separated workflows that are right from workflows that are merely easy	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 3

The Segmentation Layer

You tier on what's filterable, not on what's strategic. The dimensions that actually predict who deserves attention rarely have clean fields, so the schema quietly writes your coverage model.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Basis of your account tiers	Tiers reflect strategic predictors of attention need, even ones without a native field	Tiers are built on ARR band, industry dropdown, and renewal date because those are the structured fields available
Strategic dimensions in your model	Stakeholder fragility, sponsor strength, and workflow embeddedness are captured and drive coverage	Those dimensions don't make it in because there's no clean field, so they're invisible to segmentation
Coverage-to-tier alignment	Highest-touch motion is staffed against accounts that genuinely need it, by your definition	You staff high-touch against whatever the platform makes easiest to group, and call it strategy
Schema independence	Your segmentation logic is documented and survives outside the tool's filter options	Your segmentation IS the tool's filter options — data-model convenience wearing a strategy costume

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
Account tiers are a strategic choice, not a side effect of which fields are filterable	1-5
Strategic dimensions without native fields still shape your coverage model	1-5
Your highest-touch staffing maps to genuine need rather than ease of grouping	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

SECTION 4

The Exit Layer

This is the layer that makes the other three real. If you offboarded in 90 days, the data would migrate — but how much of your thinking would survive? That answer is your Vendor-Default Ratio.

Criteria	What Good Looks Like	What Bad Looks Like
Portability of your definitions	Your definition of health is expressed cleanly enough to rebuild in any blank tool	Your definitions exist only as the platform's configuration and can't be restated without it
Portability of your tiering logic	Your segmentation rationale survives a migration intact, independent of the schema	Your tiers would dissolve the moment you left, because they only existed as platform filters
Portability of your workflows	Core motions are documented as deliberate process that any tool could implement	Your motions are the platform's IA — they evaporate without the screens that produced them
Known Vendor-Default Ratio	You've run the test across core decisions and know exactly what share you can't change without permission	You've never computed it — your strategy is filed under 'software' and you pay rent on it yearly

Score This Section

Criteria	Score
Your core definitions, tiers, and workflows are documented well enough to rebuild in a blank tool	1-5
A 90-day migration would preserve your operating model, not just your data	1-5
You have computed your Vendor-Default Ratio and know which decisions aren't actually yours	1-5

Your Score: ____ / 5

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Your Scorecard

Dimension	Your Score	Max
1. The Definitions Layer	_____	5
2. The Workflow Layer	_____	5
3. The Segmentation Layer	_____	5
4. The Exit Layer	_____	5
TOTAL	_____	20

Total Score	Assessment	What It Means
16-20	Uncuttable	Embedded, measurable, strategically irreplaceable.
12-15	Defensible	Solid but gaps remain. Focus on lowest dimension.
8-11	Vulnerable	Real risk ahead. Treat as urgent.
4-7	Critical	Cannot survive scrutiny. Major changes needed.

What to do next: Take your lowest-scoring section and build a 30-day action plan. One at a time. Then share this with leadership -- not to ask permission, but to show you know where the gaps are.

You think you bought a system of record. You bought a system of constraint.

-- Kuber

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